

Interesting Facts

Some interesting incidents, memorable events and little-known facts from the lives of scientists...

KRISHNA MURTY KOMMAJOSYULA

Intel Inside

Intel was founded by Robert Noyce, along with Gordon Moore and Andrew Grove. The headquarters building is named 'Robert Noyce Building.'

While presently almost every PC has at least one Intel chip, Noyce thought 'it seemed ridiculous' to build a home computer.

Noyce later recalled, "Long before Apple, one of our engineers came to me with the suggestion that Intel ought to build a computer for the home. And I asked him, 'What the heck would anyone want a computer for in his home?'"

Black-market radio

During World War II, the radios used by the forces were heavy and erratic, and not designed for jungle warfare. Kilby wanted to improve the situation and travelled to Kolkata, India, for a truckload of black-market radio parts. Soon, he succeeded in building smaller, more reliable radios for the troops. His invention of integrated circuit stems from this attitude, "If something does not meet your requirements, rebuild."

First actual bug

While she was working on a Mark II Computer at a US Navy research lab in Dahlgren, Virginia, in 1947, a computer problem baffled Grace Murray Hopper and her team. When they opened the machine, they found a moth inside, stuck in a relay. Removing the offending creature, she remarked that they were 'debugging' the system. Hopper pasted the creature into her log book and noted, "First actual case of a bug being found!"

The remains of the moth can be found in the group's log book at the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of American History in Washington, DC, USA.

She is credited with the terms

commercial silicon transistor by April 14, 1954.

Flight path of bees

When Alan Turing was around the age of seven, the family went on a picnic in Ullapool, Scotland.

Thrilled at the honeybees all around, Alan got a brilliant idea of getting honey for their afternoon tea. He intently watched a few bees, plotted their flight paths and calculated the position of the hive. Soon he reached the spot and presented a treat for the family.

Turing is said to have learnt reading only in three weeks, at a very early age.

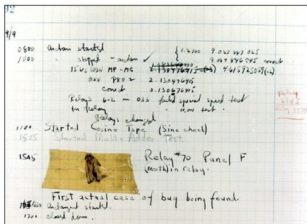
Alan Turing is regarded as the father of modern computer science and the father of artificial intelligence.

Saintly scientist

In May 1901, a scientist was adding finishing touches for his lecture at the Royal Society, London. A telegram from an industrialist seeking an immediate meeting disturbed him as he had no time to meet anyone, even a multimillionaire. He declined the invitation and received a counter reply from the industrialist informing the scientist that he was coming down to London himself.

As the scientist was about to leave for the lecture, there came Major Stephen Flood Page, the managing director of the Marconi's Wireless and Telegraph Company, carrying a handful of papers.

The scientist later recalled his conversation with Page, "He made an earnest request not to divulge all valuable research



Remains of the moth found in the group's log book at the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of American History in Washington, DC, USA (Courtesy: Wikipedia)

'bug' and 'debug' for computer errors and how to fix them. Hopper led the team that invented COBOL (common business-oriented language), the first user-friendly business computer software program.

Silicon transistors? Impossible!

On May 10, 1954, at the Institute of Radio Engineers (IRE) National Conference on airborne electronics in Dayton, Ohio, there was a serious discussion and the speakers were of the general opinion that the silicon transistor was a long way off or probably impossible. Taking out those tiny little devices from his coat pocket, Teal announced, "Contrary to what my colleagues have told you about the bleak prospects for silicon transistors, I happen to have a few of them here in my pocket." Gordon Teal and his team created the first